Week 6

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 2 · LESSON 2

Monotheism

BIG IDEA

Monotheism is more than the claim that one God exists: it is the view that a single, personal, all-powerful Creator has made himself known. In Exodus 6 God reveals himself to Moses as Yahweh, a covenant-remembering, redeeming God who pursues his creation, which sets up everything Christianity will claim.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. In Exodus 6 God tells Moses that Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob knew him as God Almighty, but not by his name, the Lord.
2. The name Yahweh, 'I am who I am,' reveals God's personal nature, his holiness, and a covenant becoming more real than before.
3. Having covered naturalism (the West) and pantheism (the East), the case for Christianity must first show a single, personal, all-powerful Creator exists.
4. Monotheism is a worldview containing Judaism, Christianity, and Islam; it means leaving the buffet and ordering the most consistent, coherent dish off the menu.
5. God is not a creator who walks away; he is actively engaged in history, redeeming and chasing after his image-bearers even after we screwed it up.
6. That personal, pursuing God sets up what Jesus does, the Holy Spirit, and the Trinity; coming weeks build the case that Christianity within monotheism is true.

SCRIPTURE IN THE VIDEO Exodus 6:1-5

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. What changes between knowing God as 'God Almighty' and knowing him by name as Yahweh?
2. What would it look like to view the world as if one personal God cares about and pursues you individually?
3. How would a monotheistic worldview change your thoughts on morality, justice, love, and how you act at school?
4. How could Christians looking through this lens actually influence the culture, rather than just being influenced by it?

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WEEK 6 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Why Exodus 6

0:05 One of my favorite passages in Scripture is Exodus 6. Why Exodus 6? Well, believe it or not, it's not because of Moses. And it's not because Moses is on the brink of the Israelites leaving Egypt, or because of this really cool escape plan that Moses is going to lead the nation of Israel on. No, believe it or not, here's why: because we discover something about God that we did not previously know, from the very beginning of Scripture all the way up to now.

0:39 In verse one of chapter six, the Lord said to Moses, "Now you will see what I will do to Pharaoh. Because of my mighty hand, he will let them go; because of my mighty hand, he will drive them out of his country." God also said to Moses, "I am the Lord. I appeared to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob as God Almighty. But by my name, the Lord, I did not make myself known to them."

1:13 "I also established my covenant with them to give them the land of Canaan, where they lived as aliens. Moreover, I have heard the groaning of the Israelites whom the Egyptians are enslaving, and I have remembered my covenant." I love this passage, because this is where we start to see God in a different light — as more than just this idea of God Almighty.

The personal nature of God

1:38 Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob saw God as God Almighty. All that means is the God who is better than every other god, the Creator God, just this person up here. Now, there is some relational stuff going on with those three, but not in the same way that we see it with Moses. He makes the covenant, but here he remembers the covenant, and the covenant is becoming more of a reality than it was before. This is where we start to see the personal nature of God.

2:12 And that is incredibly important when we start talking about monotheism, because we're not just talking about the fact that a singular God exists. We're talking about something slightly more than that. We talked about naturalism, the dominant view of the West. We talked about pantheism, the dominant view of the East. We talked about the conversions of the two and how they don't work on the buffet. We talked about all of those things. Monotheism really is the view that God has made himself known — that God has made himself known to us in a very personal and very real way.

Before we go any further

2:47 But before we make a case for Christianity being true, before we go any further — we've talked about what truth is, and about logic and faith and apologetics. We've talked about worldviews, and we've talked about naturalism. We've talked about pantheism. Before we go any further — before we talk about the resurrection, and before we talk about Scripture, and before we talk

about how God has made himself known — we need to be able to show that there is a single, personal, all-powerful creator.

Monotheism as a worldview

3:20 So I want to make something really clear here. We're talking about monotheism as a worldview, and within that worldview you have other religions as well. You have Judaism, you have Christianity, but you also have Islam. When we're talking about the buffet of a bunch of worldviews, and when we're talking about monotheism, we're saying: listen, we're going to put the buffet aside, and we're going to order off a menu and get the actual dish that we know is the best possible dish, the one that satisfies us the most and gives us the proper nutrients.

3:51 In other words, the worldview that is most consistent, the worldview that is most coherent, and the worldview that speaks to reality the best. Next week and moving forward, we're going to talk specifically about why Christianity, within the framework of monotheism, is true, and the rest of them will go away. But for this right now, we're just talking about monotheism in general.

4:19 We're talking about the idea of a loving, personal God. When we talked about pantheism, we talked about the idea that there needs to be some kind of distinction. So we're going to take that distinction and take it one step further, and talk specifically about the idea of a personal, caring God. But I could take that even one step further. If you go back to Exodus 6 and look at what God says, he says, "I am the Lord. I appeared to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob as God Almighty." He appeared to them in one way.

A God who redeems

4:55 But by himself, by his name, the Lord — this is again going back to the idea of Yahweh, I am who I am, the name of God, the utter holiness of God, the other-than-ness of God. God takes who he is a step further in front of Moses and says, I am more than just God Almighty over everything else. I am who I am, Yahweh. That kind of describes what this looks like, and we can add into our focus the idea of a God who redeems.

5:33 He is a God who is not just out there creating things and leaving it alone. We're talking about a God who is actively engaged in history, redeeming and pursuing his own creation, which is made in his image. He is chasing after us, even after we screwed it up. He is chasing us down, drawing us back to him, because of his love for us. That's pretty profound. That sets us up for what Jesus does. That sets us up for belief in the Holy Spirit. That sets us up for the belief in the Trinity that gives us a better understanding of who God is, as we move into what this idea of monotheism actually looks like.

Back to your tables

6:19 So we've had you take your students — especially in small groups, and working through the Bible study in large group — and really get a feel for how naturalism and how pantheism have infiltrated and influenced our current culture. Now I want you to back out of that for a second

and return to tables. I want you to explore with your students how looking at the world through the eyes of a monotheistic worldview could actually influence the culture.

6:51 Because ultimately, as Christians, we are called to get into our culture and impact our culture for the gospel. So what does that look like? How then does your worldview change? Even for your students who maybe don't see the world through a monotheistic worldview just yet, encourage them to take a step back, and ask them: what would it look like if I viewed the world that way?

7:18 What would it look like if I saw God as one God; more than one God, as a personal God; more than just a personal God, as one who cares and is actually pursuing me individually? How would that change your students' lives? How would that change their thoughts on morality? How would that change their thoughts on justice? How would that change their thoughts on love, and on their relationships with their friends and their family? How would it even change how they function at school? How would their entire lives change if they thought that way? So have them explore what that looks like, and encourage them to try it out and see what happens. And then, as we continue to move forward, we'll be building the case that within the monotheistic framework, Christianity represents absolute truth.